to stay. Leading Rose up one level, he brought her into a cavernous room lined with small windows, colossal machines clacking and wheezing to the ceiling. He indicated an empty stool in a row where women were settling for the shift. In front, a wooden table, and beyond it, a moving rubber belt with passing brass cylinders. The Meister tapped the woman who had just sat down on the shoulder and motioned to Rose with two fingers, pointing to his eyes: watch.

The woman's gloved hand lifted a cylinder off the rubber belt. Dipping her brush into a bowl of amber-tinted liquid, she coated the brass until it gleamed. Then, she placed it in a wire basket on the table.

"*Verstanden*?" the Meister asked, looking at Rose intently.

She nodded. He motioned to her to sit down and start.

The bench was hard, but she tried to forget it, hoping she would get used to it. Rose put on the glove, lifted the brass piece off the conveyor belt, and then painted it with the clear shellac. She hadn't realized how sticky the lacquer was until the woman beside her said, "*Nein*," and wagged a finger at Rose. She pointed at the uneven lumps on one side and made a circular motion with her hand, as if to say she should apply the layer evenly. Rose put the part in the wire basket and took the next one. This time, she was more careful, and the woman nodded and gave a thumbs-up.

A large white-faced clock hung on the wall. Rose kept glancing at it, wondering how long she'd be required to sit on the bench without a break. After an hour, the Meister counted thirty cylinders in the basket. The woman gave Rose a sour look. The Meister shook his head and said, "*Hundert*." Rose nearly stumbled off the stool. He checked her neighbor's basket and counted one hundred and ten. Rose nodded. She would try harder. Maybe she'd been too careful with the lacquer, which slowed her down.

After three hours, the Meister tapped her shoulder to signal a stop. Rose's fingers were numb from gripping the brush. She put it down, removed her glove, stood, and stretched her legs. She rubbed her shoulders; her back felt as hard as rocks.

When the Meister turned away to answer a question, her neighbor winked, dropped two cylinders into Rose's basket, and shuffled downstairs to the canteen.

"*Danke schön*," Rose said.